

11, The Similarities Between Byzantium and China, Especially in the Behavior of Their Rulers

To a Chinese person like myself, the most dramatic and simultaneously the most profoundly sigh-inducing aspect of Byzantine history is how astonishingly similar the events unfolding in these two vastly separated nations were.

Archaeological research conducted on pre-Arab-conquest Byzantine villages along the banks of the Orontes River (奥龙特斯河) in Syria has revealed something extraordinary. When selecting sites and constructing their dwellings, local residents heavily prioritized defense. Their structures featured central courtyards and were mostly two-story buildings—humans inhabited the second floor, while livestock were penned on the ground floor. Furthermore, the villages glaringly lacked public architecture.

For anyone with extensive experience visiting museums in our country, this specific design and layout is shockingly identical to the pottery architectural models (陶楼/坞堡模型) proliferating during the Eastern Han Dynasty, which depicted the rural villages of northern China during the initial stages of **feudalization**. *(From a functional perspective, it is obvious that such architecture represented a transitional state from the manors of landed aristocrats to the castles of feudal lords. Of course, the architectural prowess of ancient China fundamentally could not rival that of the Mediterranean region, hence the two-story structures depicted in Eastern Han artifacts look considerably more strained).*

What a potent proof this is that societies situated in the exact same social stage under similar natural conditions will inevitably make highly analogous choices!

When Arab Muslims conquered a colossal expanse stretching from India to the Atlantic Ocean in merely a century, the Byzantine Empire suddenly appeared to be tottering on the brink of collapse. At this exact juncture, the rulers of the Byzantine Empire resorted to the exact same stratagem as their Chinese peers: **Releasing certain feudal factors to survive the crisis!**

Although written records are scarce (*allegedly because a massive volume of documents was incinerated during the Iconoclastic Controversy*), one can still discover from limited evidence that after Byzantium suffered devastating blows—losing the Levant, Egypt, and North Africa—a military institution known as the "**Thema system**" (军区制) emerged.

Financially strapped, the empire abandoned attempting to maintain and arm the troops of these military districts using cash as it did in the past. Instead, it relied on the exploitation of designated lands within the districts, granting land as remuneration for soldiers' military service. This forged the military-land-tenure system (军役土地制) Byzantium adopted to counter the Islamic threat.

A Chinese reader easily realizes that, absent supplementary data, what we are looking at is essentially the Byzantine version of the so-called "**Fubing system**" (府兵制 / Divisional Militia system) operating from the Western Wei to the early Tang Dynasty! Even more fascinating is that, although we do not know precisely during which period of the 7th century the Thema system emerged, at that very moment, China's Fubing system had not yet entirely vanished.

Military-tenure lands rapidly expanded nationwide. These land-grant soldiers, brimming with the fervor to defend their own homes, served as the absolute mainstay in resisting invasions. Factually speaking, Byzantium's frontier crisis was indeed contained. Faced with an existential crisis, the

Byzantine monarchs had no choice but to rely heavily on these soldiers, who were progressively transforming into **feudal lords** (封建领主).

For example, during the **Iconoclasm** (破坏圣像运动)—which persisted intermittently for a century—several Byzantine emperors acted twofold. On one hand, under the guise of prohibiting idolatry, they cracked down on the Christian Church, fortifying the emperor's absolute authority relative to the Church. On the other hand, the lion's share of the expropriated Church lands fell into the hands of the **military aristocracy** (军事贵族) as fiefs, massively accelerating the **feudalization** (封建化) process of the entire nation!

By the latter half of the 8th century, as the Arab Empire inherited the classical systems of the conquered regions, the eastern frontiers of the Byzantine Empire became secure once again. At this time, the primary threats the empire faced were barbarians undergoing their own **feudalization** processes in the direction of the Balkans, such as the Bulgarians, as well as occasional threats from the Rus' people in the north. But the military strength of these enemies was insufficient—especially when confronting the defensive systems in and around Constantinople. At most, they would reach the suburbs and then demand a ransom to leave it at that.

Not to mention, Byzantium possessed an ideological secret weapon: **Orthodox Christianity** (*although the Great Schism between the Eastern and Western Churches had not yet formally occurred*). As the religious and cultural motherland of these potential enemies, Byzantium occupied an overwhelmingly dominant psychological position, making strategies like "using barbarians to control barbarians" (以夷制夷) effortlessly effective.

By the latter half of the 9th century, the Abbasid Caliphate began to disintegrate amidst its own **feudalization** process. The threat posed by the fragmented emirates of the early **feudal period** (封建时期) was far less dire than that of a unified Caliphate. The Byzantines were even capable of launching counteroffensives against the Muslims, such as the reconquest of Crete.

By the 10th century, Byzantium stood as the solitary surviving relic of the classical era, standing out like a crane among a flock of chickens (鹤立鸡群) on the eastern shores of the Mediterranean. While neighboring regions plunged into disintegration due to their **feudalization** processes, Byzantium's relative advantages actually expanded—highly likely including its commercial advantages.

Internally, however, the degree of **feudalization** within this regime had already grown phenomenally high. For example, we still possess knowledge of the poetry generated within the society of **feudal lords** along the empire's eastern frontier back then. There existed a genre of poetry perfectly situated somewhere between the *Chansons de Geste* (武功歌 / Songs of Heroic Deeds) of European **feudal** knights and the Frontier Poetry (边塞诗) of China's Tang Dynasty. (*Fascinatingly, Byzantine society was indeed suspended exactly between these two types of societies*). These works predominantly extolled the ferocious martial prowess of the generals and soldiers on the Byzantine frontiers. Among them, the epic tale of a hero named **Digenes Akritas** (迪格内斯-阿克里塔斯) is exceptionally legendary; there was likely not a single soul across the entire Near Eastern world back then who did not know his name!

However, although Byzantine emperors could acutely realize that **feudalization** possessed an unparalleled superiority in resisting foreign enemies, they were equally aware that it constituted a highly dangerous enemy to an absolute monarch! In fact, around the turn of the 7th and 8th centuries, the emperors had already tasted the bitter fruits of army mutinies.

The Byzantine emperors found themselves trapped in a structural dead end. On one hand, they lacked the ruthless mechanisms of Chinese emperors capable of utterly crushing the **feudal lords**, reducing them to a mere landlord class posing absolutely zero threat to imperial power. On the other hand, they were glaringly unwilling to relinquish their exalted status as the universal monarchs inheriting the legacy of Rome, nor their cherished bureaucratic systems. It was impossible for them to proactively converge toward the **feudal system** (封建制度) already realized in Western Europe—where the monarch merely acted as the highest-ranking among all **feudal** aristocrats (*primus inter pares*), constrained by a multitude of **feudal** contracts.

Under these circumstances where the state degenerated into a "chimera" (四不像 / neither fish nor fowl), it was fundamentally impossible for the Byzantines to discover a method for long-term political stability. The emperor himself could not even form a potent deterrent against the formidable aristocrats under his rule! Aside from the sheer inertia of people obeying the emperor, the only recourse was likely utilizing the central treasury—fattened by commercial activities—to organize a powerful standing army.

Consequently, the moment Byzantine emperors perceived a reduction in external pressure, they would spawn the exact same idea as Chinese monarchs: **Prioritize the liquidation of "potential enemies" domestically!**

The most illustrious monarch of the Macedonian dynasty, Basil II (巴西尔二世), was precisely a monarch cut from the exact same cloth as Li Shimin (李世民 / Emperor Taizong of Tang). They both relied heavily on their spectacular martial achievements in suppressing rebellions and conquering enemies to massively fortify monarchical power, throwing the process of **feudalization** into full reverse! (*Though, naturally, Basil II's capacity to reverse history was nowhere near comparable to Li Shimin's*).

Basil II utilized every conceivable machination to sever the ties between the aristocrats and their land. He contrived methods to confiscate their estates and prevent them from acquiring new land through purchase or donation. He frequently ordered military redeployments to harass the aristocrats relentlessly, and simultaneously hiked the taxes levied upon **feudal lords**.

Factually speaking, while he was alive, he indeed leveraged the formidable prestige forged through decades of constant warfare to enforce many of these policies. To use a Chinese phrase, he "*vigorously struck down the local powerful elites*" (有力打击了地方豪强).

Such machinations merely brought about a fleeting era of brilliance, but in reality, **they shoved the nation a massive step closer to the abyss of death!** Although Byzantium possessed a magnificent capital like Constantinople, it could not hide behind a massive plateau and sustain a closed, self-sufficient universe for millennia like China did. As Western Europe began entering the High Middle Ages, and the nomadic tribes of the Eurasian Steppe flooded into the **feudalized** Islamic world, the Byzantine Empire's life entered its final countdown!

However, there is a fascinating anecdote worth mentioning here. As the Middle Byzantine Empire marched toward revival in the 10th century, Byzantium once again displayed a panorama of classical prosperity.

Byzantine scholars imported from the disintegrating Arab Empire (*while naturally conducting their own excavations as well*) the achievements of classical civilization collected and organized by Arab scholars, alongside new discoveries the Arabs had forged.

Subsequently, propelled by Crusader assaults on Byzantium and the ultimate demise of the Byzantine Empire itself, these academic achievements journeyed to **feudal** Europe—either through outright plunder or carried by fleeing exiles.

Across this vast expanse stretching from the Atlantic Ocean to the mountains of Afghanistan—constituting the mainstream world of human civilization—the **"temporal lag" (时差) generated by the varying social developmental stages produced this profoundly dramatic impact!** And the European Western society that ultimately reaped the final harvest was undeniably the luckiest of all.

11，拜占庭与中国的相似性，特别是统治者的表现

在我这样的中国人看来，拜占庭历史最戏剧性也最令我唏嘘的一点是，这两个相距遥远的国家曾经发生过多么相似的事啊。考古学家们在叙利亚的奥龙特斯河（Orontes River）两岸对于阿拉伯征服之前的拜占庭村庄所进行的考古研究表明，当地居民的房屋在选址和修建时重视防御，存在居中的庭院，房屋多为二层，人在二楼居住而牲畜圈养在一楼，村庄缺乏公共建筑。对于那些对于我国的博物馆有丰富参观经历的人来说，这种设计和布局实在是和东汉时期大量出现的陶器模型所描绘的封建化初期中国北方农村实在太像了（这是明显的，从功能上看这种建筑属于土地贵族的庄园向封建领主的城堡进行过渡的状态。当然我国古代的建筑水平实在无法与地中海地区相比，因此东汉文物中所显示的二层建筑看着勉强了许多）。这是在相似自然条件下处于相同社会阶段的社会将做出高度类似的选择的一个多么有力的证明！

当阿拉伯穆斯林在短短百年间征服了从印度到大西洋的庞大疆域，拜占庭帝国一时间仿佛摇摇欲坠。这个时候拜占庭帝国的统治者再次采取了跟中国同行一样的伎俩：释放出一些封建因素以渡过难关。尽管记载很少（据称是因为圣像破坏运动时期的大量文献被销毁了），但是人们还是能够从有限的证据中发现当拜占庭因为失去黎凡特、埃及和北非而遭到重大打击之后，一种名为军区制的军事体制出现了。在财政上捉襟见肘的帝国不再试图像过去用现金供养并武装这些军区的军队，而是依靠军区内特定的土地经营，以赐予土地作为士兵进行服役的回报，这形成了拜占庭在应对伊斯兰威胁时所采取的军役土地制。中国人很容易意识到，如果再没有其他资料进行补充的话，从眼下的内容看这其实就是西魏到唐朝初年所谓府兵制的拜占庭版本。更有意思的是，虽然我们不知道军区制出现在七世纪中具体哪个时期，但是此时中国的府兵制还没有完全消亡。军区土地迅速扩大到全国，这些获得土地的士兵充满保卫家园的热情，在抵抗侵略的过程中起到了中流砥柱的作用，而且从事实上看，拜占庭的边境危机确实被遏制了。在生存危机面前，拜占庭君主不得不倚仗这些日益成为封建领主的军人，例如在断断续续持续了一个世纪的破坏圣象运动中，几位拜占庭皇帝一方面以禁止圣像崇拜为名打击基督教会，加强了皇帝相对教会的权威，另一方面被没收的教会土地大部分进入了军事贵族手中成为封地，加速了整个国家的封建进程。

到八世纪后半叶，随着阿拉伯帝国继承了被征服地区的古典体制，帝国的东部边境重新变得安全起来。而此时帝国主要面临的威胁是巴尔干方向正在进行封建进程的如保加利亚人这样的蛮族，北方的罗斯人也偶尔成为威胁。但是这些敌人的军事力量还不够强大，特别是面对君士坦丁堡以及附近的防御体系时，他们顶多打到城郊然后要一笔钱回去了事。更不要提拜占庭还有一个思想上的秘密武器，那就是东正教（虽然当时东西教会没有正式分裂），拜占庭作为这些潜在敌人的宗教文化上的母国，在心理上处在一种极大的优势地位，因此用起以夷制夷这样的手段得心应手。到九世纪后半叶，阿拔斯王朝（Abbasid Caliphate）在封建化过程中开始解体，那些封建时代早期零零碎碎的埃米尔国的威胁远不如统一的哈里发国大，拜占庭人甚至能够对穆斯林发动收复克里特岛这样的反击。到了十世纪，拜占庭作为仅存的古典时代遗迹在地中海东岸显得鹤立鸡群，在附近地区因为封建化进程而陷入解体的同时，拜占庭的相对优势扩大了，这很可能也包括商业上的。而在拜占庭帝国内部，这个政权的封建化程度已经相当高，例

如我们现在还能知道当年帝国东部边境封建领主社会中产生的诗歌，其中有一种诗歌题材介于欧洲封建社会骑士的武功歌和中国唐代的边塞诗之间（有趣的是拜占庭社会确实处于这两种社会之间），这些作品大多传颂拜占庭边地将士的勇猛善战。其中有一位叫做迪格内斯-阿克里塔斯（Digenes Akritas）的英雄故事尤为传奇，他在当年的整个近东世界恐怕无人不知无人不晓。

然而，拜占庭的皇帝虽然能够意识到封建化既在抵御外敌上具有无可比拟的优势，但同时对于专制君主来说又是危险的敌人，实际上在公元七、八世纪之交皇帝们就已经尝到了军队叛乱的苦果。拜占庭皇帝既没有中国皇帝那样的手段能够彻底压制封建领主使之成为对皇权不构成任何威胁的地主阶级，又显然不愿意放弃自己作为继承罗马的普世君主的崇高地位和官僚体制，不可能主动向当时西欧已经实现的封建制度靠拢，仅仅作为所有封建贵族中级别最高的那一个，受到各种各样的封建契约限制。在这种国家陷入“四不像”的情况下，拜占庭人不可能找到长期稳定政局的办法，甚至皇帝本人没办法对治下的强大贵族形成有力的威慑，除了人们服从皇帝的惯性以外，恐怕就只有利用受益于商业活动的中央财政组织一支强大的常备军。而一旦拜占庭皇帝认为外部压力减小的时候，他们就会和中国君主产生一模一样的想法：优先清算国内的“潜在敌人”。马其顿王朝最负盛名的君主巴西尔二世（Basil II）就是和李世民一样的君主，他们仰仗自己戡乱和征服的武功大肆强化君主权力，在封建化的道路上开倒车（当然巴西尔二世开倒车的能力显然不能跟李世民比）。巴西尔二世千方百计地削弱贵族和土地之间的联系，想办法没收他们的土地并避免他们通过购买和馈赠获得新的土地，频繁进行军事调动让贵族们不堪其忧，增加封建领主的赋税。事实上，他活着的时候确实用自己常年征战中树立起的威信把很多政策推行了下去，用中国人的话说，“有力打击了地方豪强。”

这种做法只是带来了一时的辉煌，却是把国家向死亡往前推了一大步，拜占庭虽然有君士坦丁堡这样宏伟的首都，却无法像中国一样躲在高原后面千百年间自成一统。随着西欧开始进入中世纪盛期，欧亚大草原上的游牧民族涌入封建化的伊斯兰世界，拜占庭帝国的生命进入倒计时。不过这里还有一件值得一提的趣事，随着中期帝国在十世纪走向复兴，拜占庭又显示出了一幅古典繁荣的景象。拜占庭的学者从正在解体的阿拉伯帝国那里引进了（当然他们自己也在发掘）经由阿拉伯帝国的学者收集和整理的古典文明成果以及创造的新成果，而随着十字军对拜占庭的进攻以及拜占庭的衰亡，这些学术成就又以掠夺或者流亡者携带的方式前往封建欧洲。再从大西洋延伸到阿富汗山地的这样一片广大的，作为人类文明主流的世界中，社会发展阶段不同而产生的时差就是这样产生了戏剧性的影响，而最终获益的欧洲西方社会无疑是幸运的。